
Inherited Shame

When you carry a shame that isn't yours

4 psychology approaches · by EvaTalk

TO BEGIN

When you carry a shame that isn't yours

Shame is sometimes passed down in silence: a parent's undigested shame, a 'shameful' family event, or messages received as a child ('you should be ashamed'). You end up carrying a shame that isn't yours — as if it defined you.

This guide helps you tell this inherited shame from who you truly are, and set it down.

YOUR INTENTION

A shame you carry, perhaps without it being yours: _____

Guilt vs shame

Guilt says 'I did something bad'; shame says 'I AM bad'. Inherited shame is carrying a family's shame (a secret, an event, a shamed parent) as if it said something about you.

Understanding this difference is starting to give back what isn't yours.

Example

Léa carried a diffuse, causeless shame; understanding it came from a family secret freed her of a weight.

Distinguish

What you carry: guilt (an act) or shame (about your being)?

Not mine

Write: 'This shame comes from my history, not my worth.'

Takeaway — Shame says 'I am bad' — inherited, it says nothing about your worth.

'There's something bad in me'

'Deep down, I'm worthless', 'there's something shameful in me', 'if they knew, they'd reject me': shame lies, and makes you believe you're the problem.

Spotting it as a learned lie loosens its grip.

Example

'I'm fundamentally bad' overwhelmed Sami, until he saw it was shame talking, not the truth.

Spot the shame

Note a shame thought about your being · a fairer version.

Shame lies

Write: 'Shame lies: I'm not the problem.'

Takeaway — Shame lies: it makes you believe you ARE the problem.

You aren't the shame you carry

You aren't reducible to a shame — least of all someone else's. Self-compassion is the antidote: shame doesn't survive light and gentleness.

You can give back, symbolically, the shame that wasn't yours.

Example

By offering herself compassion rather than contempt, Nia saw the shame lose its power.

My compassion

What kind word could you offer the part of you that feels shame?

Give back

Write: 'I give back the shame that isn't mine.'

Takeaway — You aren't the shame you carry — compassion dissolves it.

Bring shame out of silence

In practice: spot where the shame comes from (event, message, secret), and break the silence in a safe setting — shame thrives in secrecy and melts when shared with a trusted person or therapist. Naming it is already setting it down.

Shame doesn't withstand being told to someone who doesn't judge.

Example

By confiding his shame to a safe person, Karim felt its weight drop at once.

Whom to tell

Whom, safely, could you confide this shame to? _____

Tell it

Write: 'Shame melts when shared safely.'

Takeaway — Bring shame out of silence: shared safely, it loses its power.

Key takeaways

- Shame says 'I am bad'; inherited, it says nothing about your worth.
- Tell guilt (an act) from shame (about your being).
- Shame lies: it makes you believe you ARE the problem.
- You aren't the shame you carry — compassion dissolves it.
- Spot where it comes from (event, message, secret).
- Bring it out of silence: shared safely, it melts.

Your turn

My shame

Guilt or shame?	The shame thought

Setting it down

A word of compassion	Whom to confide in

YOUR JOURNEY

Your 4-week plan

Week 1

Tell guilt from inherited shame.

Week 2

Reframe 'there's something bad in me'.

Week 3

Offer myself compassion.

Week 4

Bring shame out of silence, safely.

YOUR PLAN

Your action plan

My 'shame lies' line:

The shame I give back:

Whom I'll confide in:

You weren't born ashamed — you can give back what was never yours.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not therapy. For heavy inheritances (deep shame, stubborn family patterns), support (a psychologist or psychotherapist) is a precious help. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.